



Pearl Fernandes receives the Emerging Hero award from Rohan Khaunte, Minister of Tourism, Goa. EMMANUAL YOGINI

positioned as a sports tourism destination. The state has actively promoted a #VacationGoa campaign to redefine its identity by leveraging technology. We said, 'Let people come to Goa and start working. Today, digital nomads have found their space in Goa. This innovative strategy, encompassing the four 'S's of sun, sand, sea, and software, has evolved further with the addition of the fifth 'S': sports. By incorporating sports into our narrative, we are not only providing equal opportunities to the youth but also contributing to the multifaceted development of Goa."

#### Politics must be kept aside from sport, says state Sports Minister Govind Gaude

Govind Gaude, the Hon'ble Sports Minister of Goa, delivered the keynote address.

He said he prides himself on how the state managed to pull off a successful National Games in 2023. "To host the 37th National Games was a dream for every Goan. Every national athlete was looking forward to participating in Goa. We had sleepless nights ahead of the competition. There needs to be meticulous planning to organise an event like this. We had given our best to deliver the best hospitality to our players. And they were



Sports Minister of Goa, Govind Gaude (right), felicitates Levino Dias with the Hero Unsung Champion award.

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all happy — even players who have represented India in multi-discipline events like the Asian Games."

Although the competition to get to the top has become tighter with each passing day, Gaude believes sports are blessed with better infrastructure nowadays. He said, "We have to tackle every difficulty. If you go 30-40 years back in time, there was no proper infrastructure in the country, but India was shining across the globe."

Infighting within sporting federations, says Gaude, often hampers the growth of fresh talent. He said, "There are a lot of politics in associations and federations. The news media must help out here. In every federation, there is a quarrel. We are spoiling the lives of the athletes by doing these."

The selection of athletes should be unbiased and solely based on merit, Gaude stressed. "Let's keep politics aside. We must come together to help sports grow. I have never asked associations to favour anybody. Selection has to happen on the basis of merit. We are giving the best services to our Goans. The government organisations and clubs need to work together."

During the event, Pearl Fernandes, a promising footballer, was named the Emerging Hero, while Levino Dias, a revered Goan football coach, was named the Sportstar Hero Unsung Champion.

